

When UK real estate agent Savills held an exhibition of London-based properties in Mumbai this April, the by-invitation-only affair drew over 100 people. In what was a pleasant surprise, they received calls from an additional 20 buyers later. "These enquiries were not from those who attended the exhibition," clarifies Sheetell Halai, head of Savills's India desk, "Many of the callers told us they had wanted to purchase property in London but just didn't know whom to contact."

A sizeable chunk of the buyers comprises professionals, aged between 30 and 60 years. Savills's customers are mainly high net worth individuals—CEOs of blue chip companies, investment bankers, doctors, pharmaceutical specialists and Bollywood stars. Similarly, the Dubai-based Better Homes, which came to Mumbai in December last year, has already sold 100 properties in Dubai to Indian residents, 10 per cent of whom are salaried



SECOND HOME: My Habitat (left) in Singapore is popular with Indians

February, to tap the high-potential market from India, is called the Malaysia My Second Home (MM2H). The scheme has already received 500 registrations from Indian residents and is targeting another 200 this year. "India has just entered into the top eight markets for us. It has the potential to be in the top five in the next few years," says Roslan Abdullah, director, MTB. Adds Halai, "India will be tomorrow what Russia is today in the number of investors."

This focus on the Indian customer has prompted many foreign real estate agents to set up full-fledged offices in the country. Apart from Savills and Better Homes, others with a regional presence include Damac Properties and Nakheel from Dubai, L.J. Hooker from Australia, and Knight Frank and MoneyWise Group from the UK. Hamptons from the UK is also scouting around for a place. Sebastian Siddiqui, national sales manager for India and Pakistan, Hamptons, confirms that he is shortlisting a site for his office. "Given the demand for property by Indians travelling abroad, we decided that the time is right to create our own presence here," he explains.

The sudden rush in the Indian market for homes abroad is, perhaps, the outcome of a bullish economy. With the Reserve Bank of India liberalising foreign remittances of up to \$100,000 (Rs 40 lakh) per person per financial year in May from \$50,000 (Rs 20 lakh), it has become easier for Indians to invest in immovable property abroad, without the bank's prior approval. This also means that individuals can hold foreign currency accounts with banks outside India, a step that has particularly helped the salaried professionals.

According to a report by The Knowledge Company (Technopak), India has a growing number of people in the affluent and middle classes, with the top-end doubling every year. In the last two-three years, there has been a consumption overdrive, particularly in overseas travel. The report estimates that there are about 1.6 million Indian families earning over Rs 45 lakh a year, allowing for a huge surplus of cash to be spent on 'conspicuous' consump-

DESTINATION	POPULAR LOCATIONS	PRICE
DUBAI*	Sheikh Zayed Road, Jebel Ali, Dubai Marina, Palm Islands and Emirates Hills.	Ranges from Rs 39 lakh for a studio apartment in Emirates Hill to Rs 13 crore for a 1-bedroom apartment in Dubai Marina.
MALAYSIA	Kuala Lumpur, Petaling Jaya, Subang Jaya, Puchong, Shah Alam, Klang	Ranges from Rs 36 lakh to Rs 77 lakh for a 2-bedroom apartment in Kuala Lumpur to Rs 3 crore for a bungalow.
LONDON	Knightsbridge and Mayfair, in the upper end to Canary Wharf and Wimbledon in the mid to lower end.	Ranges from Rs 6 crore for 1-bedroom flat to Rs 48 crore for 2-bedroom apartment in Mayfair, which would cost Rs 3.2 crore in Wembley.
SINGAPORE	Marina Bay, Orchard Road, Newton, Cairnhill	Ranges from Rs 1.6 crore for a 2-bedroom apartment on East Coast Road to Rs 53 crore for top-end penthouses in Marina Bay.

Source: IT Research, Agents

* Denotes freehold areas where foreigners can own property for a period not exceeding 99 years

professionals consisting of lawyers, chartered accountants, architects and media executives. "We are surprised at the number of requests we receive for the purchase of properties in Dubai," says Raja Kaushal, the company's managing director for India.

The reasons for the new-found romance with overseas homes are many. While the well-heeled were once content to stay in plush five-star hotels on exotic holidays or business trips abroad, the global village that they find themselves in today is making the

proposition of having homes in foreign lands more and more alluring. For some, it is a statement and for others, it is a necessity, borne out of frequent visits to certain destinations or the need to provide a base for children studying in these places. Says Anuj Puri, managing director, Trammel Crow Meghraj, a property services company, "An address in Dubai, Manhattan or London definitely adds value to one's market status." Appropriately enough, one of the schemes launched by the Malaysian Tourism Board (MTB) this